

Kingdom of Eswatini

MID-TERM UNIVERSAL PERIODIC REVIEW REPORT

2022- 2024

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Abbreviations

CSO	Civil Society Organisations
DGFI	Department of Gender and Family Issues
ETGPS	Educational Testing, Guidance and Psychological Services
FPE	Free Primary Education
GBV	Gender based violence
JICA	Japan International Cooperation Agency
LSE	Life Skills Education
LSEN	Learners with Special Needs
MOET	Ministry of Education and Training
NMRF	National Mechanism for Reporting and Follow-up
NSSV	National Surveillance System on Violence
OHCHR	Office of the High Commissioner for Reporting and Follow-up
OVC	Orphans and Vulnerable Children grants.
REO	Regional Education Officers
SODV	Sexual Offences and Domestic Violence
UPR	Universal Periodic Review

I. METHODOLOGY

1. Following the adoption of Eswatini's third-cycle Universal Periodic Review (UPR) Recommendations in March 2022, the National Mechanism for Reporting and Follow-Up (NMRF) undertook a collaborative and consultative process to develop the UPR Implementation Plan (UPR IP) 2023-2026. This process involved meaningful engagement with key stakeholders to ensure alignment with national priorities and the international obligations.

2. On October 21 and 22, 2024, the NMRF, in partnership with the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) and the United Nations Country Team (UNCT), convened a workshop to enhance the implementation of UPR recommendations.[1] The workshop provided a platform for duty bearers to present updates on progress in implementing the UPR IP activities, fostering a shared understanding of achievements and challenges.

3. Following this engagement, the NMRF identified thematic focus areas for the preparation of Eswatini's UPR Mid-Term Report. The focus areas include inclusive education, access to safe drinking water and sanitation, and combatting gender-based violence. To gather comprehensive data, additional information was requested from the Ministry of Education and Training, the Ministry of Natural Resources and Energy and the Deputy Prime Minister's Office, between November and December 2024. The criteria used to select the identified thematic areas was premised on the fact that the Ministries leading the implementation of the recommendations had readily available information.

4. On January 14 and 15, 2025, the initial draft of the UPR Mid-Term Report was compiled, incorporating inputs from the aforementioned stakeholders. To ensure inclusivity and accuracy, a validation session was held on February 13, 2025, with the participation of government departments, ministries, the Commission on Human Rights and Public Administration (Eswatini's NHRI), civil society organizations, the Swaziland Council of Churches, and other relevant partners.

[1] List of stakeholders that participated is attached as Annexure 1.

5. Subsequently, the report underwent internal Government clearance processes and later submitted to the Human Rights Council.

II. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

6. The mid-term report provides an overview of the progress made by Eswatini in implementing some recommendations adopted in 2022. It highlights the efforts undertaken by the country to improve the human rights situation in the period 2022-2024 focusing on the thematic areas of education, access to safe drinking water and sanitation, and combatting gender-based violence.

Achievements:

7. **Legal, Policy, and Institutional Reforms:** Since the previous review, there have been significant strides made by the country in strengthening its legal and policy framework for human rights. The significant reforms include the adoption of the Sexual Offences and Domestic Violence (SODV) Regulations in 2022, addressing Gender Based Violence (GBV) issues to ensure the holistic implementation of the SODV Act 2018. Furthermore, the National Strategy on Ending Violence (2023-2027) was adopted to mainstream gender issues in the National Development Plan. The country revised the National Gender Policy (2023-2033) which outlines the country's vision for gender equality and provides guidance and tools for stakeholders and institutions in all sectors to mainstream gender and advance gender equality and equity.

8. The Department of Gender and Family Issues (DGFI), in collaboration with Civil Society Organizations, has been actively working to raise public awareness about the Sexual Offences and Domestic Violence (SODV) Act through various initiatives. These efforts include conducting awareness campaigns through radio, television, organizing bus rank GBV prevention roadshows, and participating in national and social events to educate the public about GBV/VAC issues. Additionally, training workshops for law enforcement officers, Prosecutors, healthcare providers, and other stakeholders have been conducted to ensure effective implementation of the Act. There were Community engagement programs, such as the GBV symposium and community dialogues, which have further enhanced the understanding and reporting of GBV incidents.

9. As a result of these initiatives, there has been a significant increase in reported GBV cases, with a 50% rise between 2017 and 2023. The Government in collaboration with Development partners and Civil Society Organisations continues to strengthen prevention measures and holistic interventions for victims and survivors of violence, ensuring better access to reporting mechanisms and support services.

10. **Access to water and sanitation facilities:** Eswatini is making noticeable progress under SDG 6, to achieve universal and equitable access to safe drinking water and sanitation by 2030. In 2023, the percentage of the population with access to safely managed drinking water increased from 75% to 81.2%, primarily due to the implementation of more rural water schemes. The Government launched a pilot project to introduce solar-powered pumps, reducing the costs of water pumping for rural communities and ensuring vulnerable populations have access to clean water. Additionally, new water facility designs now accommodate persons with disabilities, promoting inclusivity across all rural water projects.

11. The Government successfully rolled out several solar-powered water projects in 2023/2024, benefiting numerous households across various regions. Building on this, the initiative is expanding in 2025/2026 to include more constituencies, with a focus on converting existing water systems to hybrid solar-powered solutions. Despite challenges posed in drought-stricken areas, the Government intends to conduct hydrogeological assessments, drilling deeper boreholes, and investing in alternative water sources to ensure long-term sustainability. Efforts to improve sanitation and hygiene have also been fruitful, with significant increases in access to safely managed sanitation services and hygiene practices between 2022 and 2023.

12. **Inclusive education:** Eswatini made significant strides in implementing several initiatives to enhance inclusive primary and secondary education. The establishment of inclusive model secondary schools through the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) increased enrolment for learners with special education needs, ensuring they have opportunities to learn. There has been a continuous provision of assistive devices to support diverse learning needs. Seven teachers completed a Degree program in Special

Education Needs at Southern African Nazarene University. Additionally, two Head-teachers and one Special Needs Inspector attended a six-week course on Strengthening Inclusive Education in Japan. These educators are now equipped with skills to foster an inclusive learning environment.

13. Further, there were several capacity building initiatives undertaken for teachers, School committees, and educating parents about the importance of sending all children to school and raising awareness about disability inclusion. Moreover, the implementation of inclusive education standards was piloted in 24 schools, which aims to guide schools towards increased inclusivity, with plans to roll out these standards in 2025.

14. Efforts were also made to remove barriers to Free Primary Education (FPE) through the amendment of the FPE Act in 2023 to increase FPE grants given to learners by 20% . The Ministry of Education also conducted various activities to promote safe school environments and collaborated with civil society organizations to address school-related gender-based violence.

15. **Integration pregnant Learners and reduction of dropouts:** In 2023, Eswatini launched the Early and Unintended Pregnancy Prevention Policy and Management Guidelines of 2022. The Ministry of Education's Inspectorate and the Department of Guidance and Counselling conducted sensitization meetings with school administrations, teachers, pregnant learners, and other students to promote non-discriminatory practices. These efforts help ensure that pregnant girls and young mothers can continue their education without stigma or exclusion, thus reducing dropout rates.

III. FOLLOW-UP TO UPR RECOMMENDATION RECEIVED

A. MEASURES TO COMBAT GENDER- BASED VIOLENCE

Recommendations 118.173,118.174, 118.176,118.177, 118.178, 118.182,118.1 85, 118.186, 118.193, 118.195

16. Eswatini made significant strides in enacting the Sexual Offences and Domestic Violence (SODV) Act(2018), which makes provisions concerning sexual offences and domestic violence, prevention and the protection of all persons from harm and acts of domestic violence amongst others. It further ensures justice for victims or survivors of all forms of violence.

17. To ensure holistic implementation of this Act, SODV Regulations were adopted in 2022. Pursuant to adopting these Regulations, stakeholders including Police Officers, Prosecutors, Social Workers, and Judicial Officers have undertaken continuous capacity-strengthening initiatives on the country's legal framework and standards for handling GBV cases. These trainings have led to improved handling of cases under SODV Act, as the functionaries have a clear understanding of the law and apply it consistently. These initiatives were a result of collaboration and support from the Development Partners as well as Civil Society Organisations.

Policies and strategies

18. In 2023, the country revised the National Gender Policy which covers a 10-year period (2023-2033). The revised policy outlines the country's vision for gender equality and provides guidance and tools for stakeholders and institutions in all sectors to enhance mainstreaming of gender and advance gender equality and equity, reduce gender stereotypes and discriminatory practices in all spheres of life including health, education, employment, agriculture and politics.

19. The Gender Policy of 2010 led to several visible results, which include;
    - The establishment of the Gender Coordination Unit by the Government has facilitated the improved participation of women and other disadvantaged groups in development programs at all levels.

- The Policy promoted gender mainstreaming in sector development programs across public, private, and civil society levels.
- There has been a focus on capacity building on gender mainstreaming and analysis for gender focal points within Government, civil society, and private sector organizations.
- The Policy promoted a conducive family environment for both men and women, supporting and promoting family structure and cohesion.

These efforts have contributed to addressing gender imbalances and promoting gender equity in Eswatini.

20. Similarly, the National Strategy on Ending Violence (2023-2027) was adopted to mainstream gender-based violence issues in the National Development Plan to assist in programming for prevention, social and behavioral change as well as protection of all vulnerable groups from violence. It therefore provides for a multisectoral framework that guides the prevention and response agenda of the country. The development of this Strategy has been informed by a Study on the Drivers of Violence against Children which was undertaken in 2016. The revised policy and strategy on ending violence is costed and has the following additional pillars: Peace and security for preparedness prompted by the 2021 civil unrest; Gender responsive budgeting an area that requires capacity development for key stakeholders including the Government; Information, Communication and Arts; Environment and natural resources including climate change to cater for drought and floods that the country has been facing. The Policy further aims at the engagement of women in the energy sector.

21. The Ministry of Education and Training (MOET) has also developed a Violence Strategy[2] to address violence issues in and around schools. MOET, through Educational Testing, Guidance and Psychological Services (ETGPS) Unit has piloted a Connect with Respect Program as a means of curbing school related gender-based violence. The Connect with Respect concepts have been integrated into the Guidance and Counselling Life skills Curriculum.

[2] Violence Prevention and Response Strategy 2020

Collaboration with CSOs

22. The Civil Society organizations including Swatini Action Group Against Abuse (SWAGAA) Kwakha Indvodza, and Nhlangano Aids Training Information and Counseling Centre (NATICC), continue to play a vital role in leading male engage network initiatives that eliminate violence and discrimination against women and girls. Further, civil society organisations coordinated by the Department of Gender and Family Issues (DGFI) continue to advocate for stronger penal measures against gender-based violence perpetrators.

Capacity Building and Awareness raising on SODV Act

23. The DGFI in collaboration with Civil Society Organisations continues to sensitise the population on the SODV Act through various initiatives:

- **Awareness Campaigns**:

24. The DGFI conducted multiple awareness campaigns held to educate the public about the SODV Act and the importance of reporting sexual and gender-based violence (SGBV). This has been done through radio, television and social events. These activities include:
    - Bus rank GBV Prevention Roadshows to address societal norms and provide information on preventing and reporting cases. A total of eight (8) GBV awareness campaigns targeting bus terminals, namely Mbabane, Hlathikhulu, Matsanjeni, Pigg's Peak, Manzini, Siteki, Nhlangano and Mankayane. This initiative has reached out to approximately 3000 people, inclusive of Vendors, bus conductors, marshals and the general members of the public, including Persons with Disabilities. This activity will continue in the next financial year (2025/2026).

    - Undertaken four (4) national and social events (Mahamba Gorge Hiking, Bushfire festival, Trade Fair, Umhlanga ceremony) to sensitize the public and young people on GBV/VAC issues, prevention of Teenage Pregnancy, and on positive parenting.

- **Promotional materials**

25. In addition, the DFGI with partners produced Information, Educational and Communication (IEC) materials branded in Violence Against Children (VAC) and GBV messages. These included Water bottles, T-shirts, Caps, key holders, and cups which were distributed throughout the campaigns. Further, branded two (2) public transport vehicles,

two (2) DPMO mini-buses, and ten (10) Police vehicles with GBV and VAC messages. This was done as a strategy for disseminating messages to the masses as well as sharing reporting lines.

- **Training Workshops**:

26. Training sessions have been conducted for law enforcement officers, healthcare providers, and other stakeholders to ensure they are well-versed in the Act and can effectively implement its provisions.

Year	Total Trainings	Target Audiences
2022	(5) capacity building workshops	GBV Shelter staff members, regional private sector (construction industry), & faith-based organisations
2023	(2) capacity building workshops	Widows, traditional leaders, and stakeholders (government, ministerial, CSOs)
2024	(5) capacity-building workshops	(2) sessions with Prosecutors, two (2) sessions with Magistrates, and one (1) session with Social Workers and Police Officers under the Domestic Violence, Child Protection and Sexual Offenses Unit

27. The training further extended to media houses through the Editors' forum. The Coordinating Assembly of Non-Governmental Organizations (CANGO) continues to provide training to journalists on reporting sensitive stories that include GBV without causing secondary trauma to the survivor. To safeguard the process, SWAGAA in collaboration with the International Commission of Jurists (ICJ) produced a guide for journalists and editors for reporting GBV cases in 2020. This document serves as a guideline for accurate and sensitive reporting.

- **Community Engagement**:

28. Community outreach programs have been organized to engage local communities in discussions of violence forms and the legal protections available under the SODV Act.

In 2024, the first Gender-Based Violence (GBV) Symposium was held, bringing together a diverse range of stakeholders to share data and discuss strategies for eliminating violence in a roundtable format. A total of four (4) community dialogues covering Ntontozi Inkhundla (Empini and Encabaneni umphakatsi) and two from Hhukwini inkhundla (Kalamgabhi and Dlangeni) were conducted during the period of 2022 to 2024. These interventions were carried out in partnership with Khulis'umntfwana and reached out to 640 parents and young people.

GBV Trends

29. As a result of the public awareness of the laws and increase in knowledge on what constitutes gender-based violence, there has been an increase in reported cases. According to the National Surveillance System on Violence (NSSV) 2024, there has been a 50% increase in reported GBV cases between 2017 and 2023, likely due to increased awareness on the types of violence and laws like the SODV Act 2018. The table below shows the numbers of GBV cases reported.

Year	**Number of cases**
2017	9102
2018	11081
2019	13062
2020	13537
2021	15987
2022	17391
2023	18236
Total	98396

30. In that period, 60% of cases were reported by females, 66% of incidents reported were perpetrated on adults above 18 and 34% to minors, alarmingly 88% were perpetrated by a person known to the survivor. It is also widely assumed that violence perpetrated by intimate partners and other close family members is the least reported, due to economic

dependence, power dynamics, shame and a cultural precedence of keeping family secrets "Tibi Tendlu".[3]

31. The findings of the NSSV 2024 depict that a larger percentage (64%) of abuse takes place at home, 22% in open field/ public places, 11% in other places, 2% in the workplace and 1% in school settings.[4] The 2021 study on drivers of Intimate Partner Violence (IPV) drew findings that socializations, globalization, individual behaviour, infidelity and trust issues are the main drivers of IPV.

32. The rate of violence against children and child sexual abuse is concerning, with 25.5% of females and 31.7% of males aged 13 to 24 having experienced any lifetime violence (includes experience of physical, sexual, and emotional violence at any age (0-24).[5]

33. To discourage the high incidence of violence against women and children, His Majesty the King publicly condemned acts of femicide, stating that there is no justification for the killing of women by their intimate partners.[6] Days later, the Deputy Prime Minister, speaking on behalf of the newly appointed Cabinet, echoed the sentiments shared by the King.

34. In ensuring cases of sexual and gender-based violence are prosecuted timely, the Directorate of Public Prosecutions has a specialised Unit (Domestic and Sexual Offences Unit) responsible for the effective prosecution of these cases including people smuggling offenses and those involving children. While specific statistics to demonstrate the increase in the number of cases enrolled at the Courts are not readily available, it is evident from the Unit's efforts and the numerous cases they have successfully prosecuted that there is a significant increase. The Government is currently developing an Integrated Electronic Case Management System. This initiative aims to streamline case management processes and provide comprehensive, data-driven insights to quantify progress for all relevant criminal justice stakeholders.

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[3] The Kingdom of Eswatini's Country Progress on the Implementation of the Beijing Declaration and Platform of Action, May 2019.
[4] NSSV 2024.
[5] as above.
[6] Speech from the Throne and End of Year Prayer Ceremony, 11 November 2023.

35. Efforts are being intensified to strengthen prevention measures and holistic interventions for the victims or survivors of violence who mainly comprise women and children. These include – access to easy reporting through toll-free numbers and the provision of shelters for those experiencing violence. Currently there are two registered shelters, namely, Zuzani Gosheni and Haven of Hope for survivors, which offers a wide range of services including psychosocial support. Zuzani Gosheni currently has 9 beneficiaries, whilst Haven of Hope houses 22 beneficiaries[7].

B. ACCESS TO WATER, SANITATION AND HYGIENE

Recommendations 118.136, 118.137,118.138

36. Eswatini under SDG 6 committed itself to achieve, by 2030, universal and equitable access to safe and affordable drinking water for all and access to adequate and equitable sanitation and hygiene for all. The proportion of the national population which has access to safely managed clean drinking water increased from 75% in 2022 to 81.2% in 2023 as a result of more rural water schemes.[8]

Rural water schemes

37. The Government has initiated a pilot rollout project under the Select Committee on Rural Electrification (SCORE) to reduce community water pumping costs by introducing solar-powered pumps as a renewable energy solution. This initiative addresses a critical challenge faced by many rural communities—the inability to afford costs associated with electricity-powered water pumping systems. By transitioning to solar-powered boreholes, the scheme ensures that vulnerable and indigent populations can access clean and affordable water without the financial burden of contributing to electricity costs.

38. As part of the Rural Water Scheme, the Government has also undertaken modifications to improve the inclusivity of water infrastructure. New facility designs now accommodate persons with disabilities (PWDs), ensuring universal access. These inclusive designs are being implemented across all projects, including four key initiatives under Mkhiweni

[7] As at 31 January, 2025

[8] Ministry of Economic Development and Planning; the National Development Plan Annual Monitoring Report, June 2024.

Constituency and St. Peter in the Lubombo region. The approach has been adopted by all implementing partners and key stakeholders to standardize accessibility in rural water projects.

39. The successful rollout of solar-powered water projects in the fiscal year 2023/2024 includes the following sites:

Project	**Region**	**Beneficiaries (Households)**
Dvokolwako (Phase 1)	Manzini	870
Mfishane	Shiselweni	660
Gege	Shiselweni	370
Gilgal-Phonjwane	Lubombo	340

40. Building on these achievements, the Government has expanded the initiative for the 2025/2026 fiscal year, adding eight (8) more constituencies. These projects involve the rehabilitation of existing water systems by converting them from electricity-powered to hybrid solar-powered solutions. The selected communities span all regions to ensure equitable distribution of benefits.

41. However, a significant challenge remains—boreholes in drought-stricken areas are increasingly drying up, threatening water security for affected communities. To mitigate this challenge, the Government intends to:
    - **Conduct hydrogeological assessments** to identify more sustainable groundwater sources before drilling new boreholes.
    - **Implement deeper borehole drilling** in areas prone to drought to access more stable underground water reserves.
    - **Introduce water harvesting and storage systems** to collect and store water during rainy seasons for use in dry periods.

- **Expand investment in alternative water sources**, such as small-scale desalination units and rainwater harvesting infrastructure.
- **Seek additional funding** to establish a comprehensive rural water scheme that ensures long-term sustainability, particularly in high-risk areas.

42. Through these strategic interventions, the government remains committed to improving access to clean water, reducing financial burdens on rural communities, and ensuring water security even in the face of climate challenges.

Access to water initiatives

43. The country has constructed and operationalised five major dams in the country namely; Mnjoli (177 Million Cubic Metres), Luphohlo (23.6 Million Cubic Metres), Hawane (2.7 Million Cubic Metres), Maguga (332 Million Cubic Metres) and Lubovane dams (155 Million Cubic Metres).

44. Interventions undertaken during the period under review:

    - Preliminary works on the Mpakeni Dam which began in 2023 are ongoing (18% complete) with construction anticipated to be completed by 2028. The dam will have a storage capacity of about 120 Million Cubic Meters. This project is set to transform agriculture and boost irrigation in the Shiselweni Region by providing reliable water supply for irrigation, benefitting both small scale and commercial farmers with consideration for flood control and aquaculture. The dam is a component of the Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Project (MNWAP) which is an infrastructure and irrigation project aimed at poverty alleviation in the Shiselweni Region. At its totality, the MNWAP is expected to cost the country around E50 billion.[9]

    - The Government is also exploring ways to construct Ethemba dam on the Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma river basins to complement the Mpakeni dam.[10]

[9] Ministry of Economic Planning and Development; the National Development Plan Annual Monitoring Report, June 2024.
[10] As above.

- A feasibility study for the construction of Nondvo Dam which will supply water along the Mbabane-Manzini corridor in the long term is ongoing.[11]
- The raising of the Hawane Dam wall by four meters to increase its holding capacity to 6.3 Million Cubic Meters is ongoing after having commenced in 2024. This project is estimated to cost around E32 million.[12] Once completed water supply for Mbabane, Ezulwini and Ngwenya towns will be improved.

45. The Government completed a pre- feasibility study in 2023 on constructing a multi-purpose dam to address the issue of power, food and water challenges by developing the Ngwempisi Dam.

Sanitation and Hygiene

46. To improve sanitation the country completed Ezulwini water Supply and Sanitation project that serves Mbabane, Ezulwini and Lobamba areas. More actions are being undertaken to implement WASH programmes including continuous construction of additional sanitation facilities. These interventions have contributed to the proportion of the population with access to safely managed sanitation services which increased from 53% to 58% between 2022 and 2023.[13]

47. Access to hygiene increased from 26% in 2022 to 55%[14] due to an increased awareness during the era of Covid-19 when washing of hands was deemed mandatory. The country managed to achieve the target of reducing open defecation from 11% in 2022 to 5% in 2023 due to active Government strengthening awareness to households and promoting the use of sanitation facilities.[15]

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[11] As above.
[12] As above.
[13] Ministry of Natural Resources and Energy Annual Performance Report 2022/2023.
[14] Multi Indicator Cluster Survey 2022
[15] Ministry of Natural Resources and Energy Annual Performance Report 2022/2023.

C. EDUCATION

Recommendations 118.159,118.160, 118.214, 118.215

Implementation of programs to facilitate access to inclusive primary and secondary education.

48. During the reporting period, 2022 to 2024, the MOET undertook the following initiatives to improve access and strengthen inclusive education in Primary and Secondary Education:

Operation of inclusive models schools

49. In 2022, Inclusive Model Secondary Schools were established through support from the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA). These schools have successfully increased the enrolment of learners with special education needs (LSEN). Mainstream schools nearby use these inclusive schools for support. School committees from neighboring schools were invited for training on disability inclusion and to adopt best practices to enhance inclusive education in their schools. The following table contains a list of inclusive schools.

Table 1 - Inclusive schools

Region	**Name of School**
Manzini	Boyane inclusive secondary school
Lubombo	Gamula inclusive secondary school
Hhohho	Enhlitiyweni inclusive secondary school
Shiselweni	Ecinisweni inclusive secondary school

50. From 2022 to 2024, routine activities were conducted to strengthen access to inclusive education. These activities focused on educating parents about the importance of sending all children to school and addressing cultural beliefs that see children with challenges as

a taboo. Awareness campaigns were carried out during school committee elections and orientation workshops in 491 schools, as well as School Development Plan trainings for new head-teachers in 147 schools.

Piloting of Standards for Inclusive Education

51. In 2023, standards of inclusive education were piloted in 24 schools (12 Primary Schools and 12 Secondary schools). The Standards are a roadmap towards guiding schools to be inclusive. During the piloting exercise, it was noted that some schools already had attained some of the Standards and others were in the process of improving to attain the standards. The standards will be rolled out in 2025.

Procurement and provision of assistive devices

52. The Ministry of Education and Training and its Partners were able to provide assistive devices and software to support the teaching and learning for learners with special education needs. The table below shows the distribution of the assistive devices.

Table 2 - SEN assistive devices distributed in the period 2022-2024

Assistive tool	Total Beneficiaries
Prodigi Connect 12	12
Braille Note Touch (BNT)	7
Dispatched Prodigi Connect at Exams Council of Eswatini (ECESWA)	4
BNT at ECESWA	5
Laptops	286, with 200 uploaded with software
Laptop, Dolphin SuperNova & Screen Magnifier (Software)	103
Laptop, Text help (Software)	103
Laptops (MTN YELLOW CARE) at Majembeni Primary	20 uploaded with software

Personalized Wheelchairs	58
Communication Devices: - Laptop: Snap & Core First, Go-Talk.	100
Quick Talker	13
Super Talker	12
Magnifying glass, bell ball at Eqinisweni	1

53. Through the provision of assistive devices, LSEN have been able to access the curriculum in different formats. The assistive devices also boost the learners' confidence and sense of belonging. Some learners with cerebral palsy who were unable to attend school due to their sitting position have now been enrolled with the aid of personalised wheelchairs equipped with a gadget.

54. Despite the above stated strides, inclusive education in Eswatini faces several challenges which includes:

- Some teachers still lack the necessary training and skills to effectively teach students with diverse needs.
- There are limited resources, including teaching materials, assistive technologies, specialised teaching methods and financial support, which hampers the implementation of inclusive education.
- The physical setups of some classrooms are not conducive to accommodate students with special needs.

Long-term and short-term training

55. From 2022 to 2024, a total number of 7 teachers were trained on a Degree program on Special Education Needs at Southern African Nazarene University with support from ESRA. The teachers are now equipped to teach and support LSEN. Moreover, two Head-teachers (School for the Deaf Primary and Boyane Inclusive Secondary School) and one regional Special Needs Inspector visited Japan for a six-week course on Strengthening Inclusive Education. Through this training, the country representatives were to learn best

practices for strengthening inclusive education and then prepare action plans for implementation in Eswatini.

56. Further to that, several capacity building initiatives on inclusive education were conducted. In 2022, a total of 17 workshops were held, benefiting 187 teachers. In 2023, the number of workshops increased to 26, benefiting 312 teachers. In 2024, 4 workshops were organized, which capacitated 168 school committees neighbouring JICA Inclusive model schools. Four workshops were held, benefiting 56 JICA school teachers, and eight additional workshops were conducted, benefiting 96 teachers.

Removal of Barriers to Free Primary Education

57. There have been reports and a few instances of schools charging additional fees beyond those covered by Free Primary Education (FPE). In such instances, implicated schools were ordered to comply with the FPE Act (2010) and Head Teachers were sternly warned to desist from such unlawful practices. Regional Education Offices (REOs) have organised several meetings to raise awareness about every learner's right to access FPE. To further eliminate the practice, the Free Primary Education Act, (Amendment of Schedule) Notice, 2023 was issued which increased the grants given to learners by 20 percent.

58. Furthermore, in an effort to remove barriers to FPE, the Ministry through the Educational Testing, Guidance and Psychological Services (ETGPS) Unit conducted educational jamborees at school level in the four regions. This was done in collaboration with different partners, where services such as birth registration and health screening for Early Detection and Early Intervention of Child Development Disorders were brought to the schools. REOs and guidance officers were trained on social accountability to enhance community engagement and strengthen ethical leadership.

59. The Unit also advocated for the development of uniform guidelines to eliminate instances where underprivileged children were sent home for not complying with the uniform dressing rules. Further, Parliamentarians were lobbied to support the reviewing of the FPE and Orphans and Vulnerable Children (OVC) grants.

Non-discrimination measures for pregnant Learners and reduction of dropouts

60. In 2023, the Ministry of Education and Training's Policy and Guidelines for the Prevention and Management of Learner Pregnancy of 2022 was launched. This policy seeks to reduce unintended pregnancies, reduce unsafe abortions, improve sexual and reproductive health (SRH) for adolescents and young people, integrate pregnant learners into schools and protect the rights of adolescents and youth.

61. Ministry of Education and Training through the ETGPS Unit in collaboration with UNESCO through the O3 project conducted sensitisation meetings on the new policy and also non-discriminatory tendencies were discussed with all head teachers from primary and secondary schools. School integration and remedial teaching were provided for pregnant girls, adolescent mothers, vulnerable children, and young people to reduce the dropout rate, supported by an EU-funded project. The project supported the development and dissemination of health packages and services to pregnant and parenting adolescents. Pregnant and parenting girls were reintegrated back into school and those who chose not to go back to school were linked to skills development initiatives.

62. Moreover, the ETGPS Unit reviewed the Guidance and Counselling Lifeskills curriculum using the Sexuality Education Review and Assessment Tool (SERAT) to align with international standards and address emerging issues. The Guidance and Counselling lifeskills is implemented as a stand-alone subject at secondary school level and is integrated into other core subjects at the primary school level.

63. The Unit also monitors and evaluates Guidance and Counselling Lifeskills programme implementation in schools and conducts quarterly LSE feedback sessions for teachers. One-hour LSE radio sessions are held on the Eswatini national radio on Saturdays, with repeats on Tuesdays. Additionally, a drama series addressing Early and Unintended Pregnancy (EUP), which consists of 38 episodes, has been aired on the radio.

64. The Ministry further conducted LSE online training for curriculum designers and mobilised resources for education support grants to assist vulnerable children. It also capacitated head teachers, teachers, Swaziland National Association of Teachers (SNAT)

and other key stakeholders on positive discipline to address issues related to learners dropping out of school.

65. To promote safe school environments, pilot schools at secondary level were trained on the nine pillars that are a building block for provision of a safe and protective environment. The nine pillars are: rights-based based socially inclusive school policies and practices, Quality, relevant, inclusive curriculum, teacher development, Enabling and inclusive infrastructure, material support, Nutrition and Health Promotion, Social Welfare services including psychosocial support, parental involvement and Leadership and Coordination. The Care and Support for Teaching and Learning (CSTL) program was piloted in 20 secondary schools and is now being rolled out to all secondary schools. The Unit collaborated with civil society organizations to address issues of violence, particularly school-related gender-based violence, through various programs.

IV. NEEDS FOR CAPACITY BUILDING AND TECHNICAL ASSISTANCE

66. The Government of Eswatini is committed to continuing the implementation of the accepted recommendations to meet both domestic and international obligations. To achieve this, Eswatini seeks technical assistance and capacity building in the following key areas:
    - Strengthening the information management capacity of the NMRF through capacity-building initiatives and the rollout of the National Reporting Tracking Database, to ensure an improved tracking, recording, and reporting on UPR and other human rights mechanisms' recommendations.

    - Alignment of legislation to the constitution and international standards as well as developing new pieces of legislation, domesticating treaties on human rights ratified by Eswatini.

LIST OF PARTICIPANTS: UPR MID-TERM CONSULTATION

Government Departments

1. Deputy Prime Minister's Office
    i. National Children Services Department,
    ii. Department of Gender and Family Issues
    iii. Department of Social Welfare
2. Ministry Of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation
3. Ministry Of Natural Resources And Energy
    i. -Department of Water Affairs
    ii. -Land Administration
4. Ministry Of Agriculture
    i. Economic Planning and Analysis
5. Ministry Of Home Affairs
    ii. Civil Registration and Vital Statistics
    iii. Department of Refugees
6. Ministry Of Education and Training
    i. -Director of Education
    ii. -Special Education Needs (SEN) Unit
7. Ministry Of Information, Communications Technology
    i. –Research, Science, Technology and Innovation
8. Ministry Of Public Works and Transport
9. Royal Eswatini Police Service
10. His Majesty's Correctional Services
11. Director of Public Prosecutions
12. Attorney General
13. Legal Aid Department

Non-Governmental Organisations

14. Commission on Human Rights and Public Administration
15. National Emergency Response Council on HIV/AIDS (NERCHA)
16. Swaziland Action Group Against Abuse (SWAGAA)
17. Federation of Organizations of the Disabled People in Eswatini (FODSWA)
18. Council of Eswatini Churches
19. Coordinating Assembly of Non-Governmental Organisation (CANGO)
20. Youth Sustainable Development Centre (YSDC)
21. Rock of Hope
22. COSPE